

1857-58

MARCH 1857

In the Dred Scott case, the Supreme Court rules that Congress cannot deprive citizens of their property, including slaves, anywhere in the United States, and that Black people are not citizens.

DECEMBER 1857

The Lecompton legislature adopts a constitution for Kansas. The status of slaves already in the territory remains unchanged. A vote will decide whether or not to allow new slaves.

APRIL 1858

Although Kansan voters reject the Lecompton Constitution, President Buchanan asks Congress to admit Kansas as a state under its terms. Congress calls for a further vote in Kansas.

AUGUST-NOVEMBER 1858

Abraham Lincoln challenges Stephen Douglas for election as U.S. senator for Illinois. Their debates bring Lincoln to national prominence, but Douglas wins the election.